


**A WIN-WIN NEGOTIATION** Piyush Goyal addresses the media along with his counterparts after the inking of the India-EFTA pact in New Delhi, Mar. 10

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commitment of $100 billion, domestic companies and joint ventures will also pool their resources, which may translate into $300 billion-$400 billion of total investment," says Sahai. Moreover, India is looking into the Mutual Recognition Agreement (MRA) for its nurses, CAs and architects. "If we have these MRAs and if our degrees are recognised by the counterpart country, access to visas will become very easy. We will see a lot of movement of professionals on a medium- to short-term basis, because these countries have an ageing population and require professionals in various sectors," Sahai says, adding that India will have a tariff advantage with countries like Norway and Iceland in industrial goods as well as agriculture, but, for Switzerland, the advantage is only on the agricultural sector and in services.

Some experts are of the view that the targeted investment through the deal is too ambitious. "I have doubts about the fact that this will be realised," says Biswajit Dhar, distinguished professor, Council for Social Development, Delhi. "Between 2000 and 2023, FDI inflows from these countries to India were just about $10 billion. Now, we are saying we will have $100 billion in 15 years. That will need a reorientation of all the plans of Switzerland, which seems to have been investing less abroad." But that should not take the sheen off what many see as a first-of-its-kind deal. ■

WEST BENGAL

# MAMATA'S LONE MARCH

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

Scattering to the winds any remaining vestige of the I.N.D.I.A. bloc in West Bengal, Trinamool Congress leader Mamata Banerjee on March 10 announced party candidates from all 42 Lok Sabha seats in the state. Among the prominent names were Mahua Moitra from Krishnanagar, signifying confidence in her even after she was expelled from Parliament; Yusuf Pathan from Baharampur, where he is likely to take on state Congress chief Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury; Shatrughan Sinha from Asansol; Kirti Azad from Bardhaman-Durgapur and Mukut Mani Adhikari from Ranaghat. The BJP MLA from Ranaghat South, Adhikari joined the TMC on March 7 after the BJP denied him a ticket. Adhikari is an influential member of the politically significant Matua community that had migrated from Bangladesh and has been clamouring for Indian citizenship for long. In recent years, many Matuas became BJP supporters due to the party's promise to implement the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA). Adhikari's joining the TMC and the Centre's announcement that it notified the rules to implement the Act on March 11 has an interesting cause-



**SHOW OF STRENGTH** ▼ Mamata Banerjee with other TMC leaders at the Brigade Parade Ground rally, Mar. 10

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